

2 Areas of study

As part of the final submission task for this unit, students choose one composition brief from a selection of four set by Edexcel.

When preparing for this task students and teachers should note the following guidance for the individual topics. Students should also be aware of the assessment criteria against which the compositions will be marked.

Area of study 1: Instrumental music

Topic 1: Composing expressively

Students should investigate the creation of different moods and emotions in music (eg by the manipulation of range, dynamics, tempo and key), and the effective transition from one mood to another either gradually or abruptly. They may write in any style for any instrumental forces, acoustic and/or synthesised, subject to the brief.

Topic 2: Variation structures — composing idiomatically for instruments

Students should investigate variation type structures, and how these may demonstrate idiomatic instrumental writing. They should learn about the practical ranges of the instruments they want to write for, and commonly-used instrument techniques and timbres. Subject to the brief they may write in any style, and for any combination of acoustic instrumental forces involving any two, three or four instruments, or for solo piano.

Area of study 2: Vocal music

Topic 3: Words and music: structure in vocal music

Students should investigate the relationship between the structure of vocal pieces and the structure of their texts by studying a variety of simple forms appropriate to the types of music they wish to compose (eg strophic, verse-plus-chorus structures). Students may write in any style, for any vocal forces (with or without instrumental/synthesised accompaniment), subject to the brief.

Topic 4: Text, context and texture

Students should investigate how different types of text are characteristic of different performance situations and how textures and styles of singing may be varied in vocal music (eg through antiphony or variations in the numbers of parts). Students may write in any style for any vocal forces (with or without instrumental/synthesised accompaniment), subject to the brief.